

Tool

Implementing Business Practices

As your business grows, you will need to institute core business practices. Implementing business practices requires several things:

- ▶ Organisation-wide ownership of and commitment to change
- ▶ Regular and effective planning and prioritization
- ▶ Deployment of the right resources and capabilities
- ▶ Resilience and continuous improvement

This tool walks you through the core steps in implementing business practices that will lead to efficiency, business resilience and growth.

Step 1: Define the ‘WHY’



The first step in implementing a new behaviours or practice at work is being very clear on what you want to do and WHY you want to do. It's important to think about why this new practice is important for you – otherwise you just won't do it. Even if you're able to see how it will benefit your organisation, think about why it is meaningful for you and for your staff. This builds ownership and gets people excited about implementing the practice.

For each of your chosen practice(s), spend time with your team to discuss:

- ▶ Why is this practice important for the organisation and therefore for each of you?
- ▶ How does it get us where we want to go?
- ▶ What will it look like if we're successful?
- ▶ What are we going to get out of this?
- ▶ How will it help the organisation?

At the end of the discussion, come up with an impact statement for the specific practice summarising what the outcome would like if you're successful. We've given an example to get you started.

YOUR IMPACT STATEMENT

Practice	Impact if successful
C1: Survey existing customers	Regularly surveying our current customers allows us to confirm whether we're meeting their needs so that we can adapt our offering accordingly

Step 2: Understand WHEN (and how often) you need to do it



Different business practices need to be done at different times. For each of the practices that you've chosen to focus on, how often do you need to implement it. Is it once a year, twice a year, every 3 months, every month every week or every day? The table below gives an overview of when and how often you need to implement each of the practices, but depending on your business needs and structure, you need to determine exactly when you'll be implementing each of your chosen practices. Effective planning and prioritisation ensures that you actually put down dates to get it done. We've given you an example to get started.

Practice	How often	Specific dates
C2: Survey existing customers	Monthly	Every 1st Thursday of the month

Remember that different practices are done at different times of the year...

Annual practices (once a year)	Semi-annual practices twice a year	Quarterly practices (once every 3 months)	Monthly practices (every month)	Weekly/daily practices
1. Review Strategy (P1)	1. Survey Existing Customers (C1)	1. Review Business	1. Plan Operations (P4)	1. Track Progress against targets (P2)
2. Compliance Review (P5)	2. Survey Former Customers (C2)	2. Survey Suppliers (C4)	2. Implement a Marketing & Sales Plan (C5)	2. Capture Money Transactions (M1)
3. Track Cash and Profitability (M2) (trend analysis)	3. Risk assessment: Compliance (P5)	3. Talent Reviews (T6)	3. Track Cash and Profitability (M2)	3. Track Inventory (O2)
4. Reduce Costs (M4)		4. Performance Review (T4)	4. Budget (M3)	4. Regular Check-in with Staff (T1)
5. Talent Reviews (T6)		5. Monitor Organisational Climate (T2)	5. Continuous Improvement in processes (O4)	5. Plan Operations
			6. Regular feedback and coaching (T3)	6. Negotiate with Suppliers (O1)
			7. Staff Learning (T5)	6. Follow Clear Operational Processes (O3)
				7. Reduce Costs (M4)

Step 3: Come up with an action plan that leverages your strengths



Organisations, teams and leaders who approach implementation from their point of strengths are able to better determine what needs to be done and address any gaps. The quadrant below helps you to identify your core strengths so that you can leverage these to get started on your practices. For your chosen practice(s), map out your action plan in terms of what you can already start using to get started and remove any barriers.

Core strengths: What do you already have in place to get started? What is the smallest change you can make today/this week?	Allies: Who is great at this? Who can we get excited about this?
Resources required: What resources/support need to implement/actualise the practice?	Removing the barriers: What are the barriers and how can you remove barriers to adoption?

Step 4: Anticipate and address the barriers



As you work through your chosen practices, you're bound to encounter challenges. Some common barriers include 'lack of time', resistance to change by staff, inability to implement the practices consistently and so on. While acknowledging these real barriers to implementation, researcher have shown that if you take time to dig deeper into why you're struggling to implement the practices, the answer is often because 'the why is not strong enough', has not been communicated/no buy-in or due to poor planning. Try to introduce a practice that your organisation is either not very good at or a practice that you really want to do – that way, you'll see a big impact from implementing it, which is motivating. And make sure it's a practice that you can implement i.e. it's feasible!

Some helpful questions to help you think about the challenges include:

- ▶ Have I chosen the right practice to implement?
- ▶ Is this practice really that important to me right now? Or should I maybe focus on a on different practice?
- ▶ Am I using the right tools to help me? Maybe I should try a different one
- ▶ Are my staff bought in? Is there a strong enough 'why' to want to do it?
- ▶ Have I allocated enough time/resources to focus on implementing this practice right now? When is a good/better time?
- ▶ Have I put in place the right reminders and milestones/small wins to keep me motivated?

Anticipated barriers	How you'll remove the barriers

Practical tips to help you implement the practices

Tip	Description	Your specific steps
Start small: Think about the practice you've chosen. How can you build on what's you are already doing? Break it into smaller manageable chunks e.g. Call 2 customers per week	What's the smallest thing you can do to get you started on this?	Tip: One of the steps you can immediately take is to download the key tool for chosen practice!
Build accountability: Schedule a regular time to check in on the progress of implementation. Recognise and celebrate every time you hit a milestone.	Who is going to going to follow up? When are they going to check-in on progress?	
Continuous improvement: What will you learn from the experience of implementing the practice? How will you document what has been learned? What will you do differently next time	Pause to reflect: When will you set aside time to review what's working and what's not working?	